



BE READY.

First half of the season

Your sessions

Fitness + Prevention & health

Program

First half of the season

Duration

18 semaines

Session

30 to 40 min

Place

Home

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Your goals

Fitness

During a match, players cover about 4 km on average, alternating walking, running, sprints and contacts (Wagner et al., 2014). What makes the difference at the end of a game is the ability to repeat intense efforts and recover quickly between them.

- **Endurance:** the base that lets you recover between actions.
- **Repeated effort capacity:** stringing sprints together without losing speed.
- **Fat loss:** increasing energy expenditure while keeping your performance.
- **General fitness:** lasting a whole match and a whole season.

The golden rules

- **Progressive:** the volume goes up week after week, never all at once.
- **Stick to the paces:** easy = you can talk; steady = a few words; hard = impossible to talk.
- On repeated sprints, stop the set if your speed drops clearly.

Fat loss: training increases energy expenditure, but the result depends mostly on food and sleep. Avoid restrictive diets, which lower performance. For support, see a registered dietitian.

When three durations are given ("12-15-18 min"), they are for levels 1, 2 and 3.

Prevention & health

In handball, the most common injuries affect the ankles, knees, shoulders and the muscles at the back and inside of the thigh. Studies show that many of them can be avoided with simple exercises done regularly: a targeted warm-up roughly halved knee and ankle injuries (Olsen et al., 2005), and a shoulder programme cut shoulder problems by 28 % (Andersson et al., 2017).

- **Injury prevention:** balance, jump landings, knee control.
- **Targeted strengthening:** knees, ankles, shoulders and hamstrings.
- **Mobility and flexibility:** hips, ankles and upper back.
- **Joint stability:** keeping your joints aligned in contacts.

The golden rules

- **Consistency before intensity:** repeating the sessions is what protects you.
- **The perfect movement:** a knee caving inwards on landing is exactly what we correct.
- These exercises should not hurt: discomfort is a signal to ease off.

These exercises prevent injuries, they do not treat them. If you are in pain right now, see a health professional before carrying on.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

How to read your sessions

- Every session is written out in full, in order: do the steps from top to bottom.
- "2-4 × 8": 2 sets at level 1, 3 at level 2, 4 at level 3, of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.
- The number in front of each exercise refers to its illustrated sheet, at the end of this document.
- If you do not know your level, read the guide again, page "Choosing your level".

Your two sessions

Timing: session 1 at least 3 days before the match, session 2 no later than 2 days before. Never the day before a match.

Weeks 1 to 4 - Into the season

Games start again: we keep the summer's strength and explosiveness without tiring the legs. Effort 6-7 out of 10. **Week 4 lighter**: one set less on every exercise.

Session 1 - the more demanding one, far from the match

1 WARM-UP		8 min	
1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back
2 FITNESS		10-12 min	
8	15-15 intervals	1-2 × 6 min	3 min
3 PREVENTION & HEALTH		10-12 min	
9	 Single-leg squat	2 × 6-8 per leg	45 s
10	 Single-leg landing	2 × 4 per leg	30 s
4 CORE AND PREVENTION		5-8 min	
11	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3-5	60 s
12	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2 × 15 s per side	30 s
4	 Plank	1-2 × 30 s	30 s
5 COOL-DOWN		5 min	
2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.			

Session 2 · lighter

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1 Light jog and running drills 2 min

2  Forward lunge with trunk rotation 5 per side

3  Glute bridge 1 × 10

4  Plank 1 × 20 s

5  Single-leg balance 20 s per leg

6  Small jump, stable landing 1 × 5

7 Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %) 2 runs walk back

2 FITNESS

10-12 min

13 Handball shuttles 4-6 runs 45 s

14 Easy run (recovery) 8-10 min

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

10-12 min

15  External rotation, arm raised 2 × 12 per arm 30 s

16  Balance with a ball 2 × 30 s per leg 15 s

17  Ankle mobility at the wall 1 × 8 per side

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18  Shoulder external rotation 2 × 12 per arm 30 s

19  Y-T-W 2 × 8 30 s

16  Balance with a ball 2 × 20 s per leg 20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

All season, you can add the optional shoulder routine on a third day (10 min, for instance before club training):

Shoulder routine · 10 min (optional)

1 PREVENTION AND MOBILITY

10 min

18  Shoulder external rotation 2 × 12 per arm 20 s

19  Y-T-W 2 × 8 20 s

20  Scapular push-ups 2 × 10 20 s

21  Upper back rotation 1 × 8 per side

Weeks 5 to 8 - Maintain with intensity

Few sets, but heavy and fast: that is what keeps strength in season. Effort 7-8 out of 10. **Week 8 lighter.**
Autumn holidays: if your league stops for 2 weeks, week 8 becomes a week of **complete rest** and week 9 a week of **work** with the 3 break sessions (end of the document), then you resume with the next block.

Session 1 - the more demanding one, far from the match

1	WARM-UP		8 min
1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back
2	FITNESS		10-12 min
8	15-15 intervals	2 × 8 min	3 min
3	PREVENTION & HEALTH		10-12 min
9	 Single-leg squat	2-3 × 8 per leg	45 s
22	 Calves: slow lowering	2 × 8 per leg	45 s
23	 90/90 hip mobility	1 × 8 per side	
4	CORE AND PREVENTION		5-8 min
11	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3-5	60 s
12	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2 × 15 s per side	30 s
4	 Plank	1-2 × 30 s	30 s
5	COOL-DOWN		5 min
2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.			

Session 2 · lighter

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

10-12 min

24	Repeated sprints	1-2 sets	3 min
14	Easy run (recovery)	5-8 min	

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

10-12 min

20	 Scapular push-ups	2 × 10	30 s
10	 Single-leg landing	2 × 5 per leg	30 s
21	 Upper back rotation	1 × 8 per side	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	 Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s
16	 Balance with a ball	2 × 20 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 9 to 12 · Keep the level

Heavy then fast contrast and short sprints keep your speed as the season's fatigue sets in. Effort 7-8 out of 10. **Week 12 lighter.**

Session 1 · the more demanding one, far from the match

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1		Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2		Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3		Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4		Plank	1 × 20 s	
5		Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6		Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7		Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

10-12 min

25		30-30 intervals	2 × 6 min	3 min
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3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

10-12 min

10		Single-leg landing	2-3 × 5 per leg	30 s
9		Single-leg squat	2-3 × 8 per leg	45 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

11		Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3-5	60 s
12		Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2 × 15 s per side	30 s
4		Plank	1-2 × 30 s	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session 2 · lighter

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

10-12 min

24	Repeated sprints	2 sets	3 min
14	Easy run (recovery)	5-8 min	

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

10-12 min

15	 External rotation, arm raised	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s
16	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	15 s
23	 90/90 hip mobility	1 × 8 per side	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	 Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s
16	 Balance with a ball	2 × 20 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 13 to 16 · Before the break

Less volume to stay fresh for the last games of the year. Effort 7 out of 10. **Week 16 lighter.**

Session 1 · the more demanding one, far from the match

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1		Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2		Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3		Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4		Plank	1 × 20 s	
5		Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6		Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7		Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

10-12 min

8		15-15 intervals	1-2 × 6 min	3 min
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3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

10-12 min

9		Single-leg squat	2 × 8 per leg	45 s
17		Ankle mobility at the wall	1 × 8 per side	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

11		Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3-5	60 s
12		Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2 × 15 s per side	30 s
4		Plank	1-2 × 30 s	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session 2 · lighter

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 FITNESS

10-12 min

13	Handball shuttles	4 runs	45 s
14	Easy run (recovery)	6-8 min	

3 PREVENTION & HEALTH

10-12 min

15	 External rotation, arm raised	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
16	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	15 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

18	 Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	 Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s
16	 Balance with a ball	2 × 20 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Weeks 17 and 18 · The Christmas break

Week 17: complete rest, no sessions. Body and mind need it. Walking, cycling or another sport for fun if you feel like it. **Week 18: a week of work** to prepare the January restart: the 3 sessions below, without equipment, on 3 non-consecutive days. The day before the restart, nothing more than an easy jog.

Session A · Legs and jumps · 25 min

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 THE WORK

15-20 min

26	 Squat	3 × 20 · 3 s descent	45 s
27	 Reverse lunge	3 × 15 per leg · 3 s descent	45 s
28	 Squat jump	3 × 5	60 s
4	 Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s

3 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B · Running · 25 min

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	 Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	 Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	 Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	 Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 THE WORK

15-20 min

8	15-15 intervals	2 × 6 min	3 min
13	Handball shuttles	4 runs	45 s
14	Easy run (recovery)	5 min	

3 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C · Core and shoulders · 20 min

1 WARM-UP

8 min

1	Light jog and running drills	2 min	
2	Forward lunge with trunk rotation	5 per side	
3	Glute bridge	1 × 10	
4	Plank	1 × 20 s	
5	Single-leg balance	20 s per leg	
6	Small jump, stable landing	1 × 5	
7	Progressive accelerations (70 %, then 85 %)	2 runs	walk back

2 THE WORK

15-20 min

4	Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s
29	Side plank	2 × 20 s per side	20 s
11	Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 4	60 s
18	Shoulder external rotation	2 × 12 per arm	30 s
19	Y-T-W	2 × 8	30 s

3 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

The exercises

In the order of the numbers used in your sessions.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

1 Light jog and running drills

Light jog, alternating side shuffles, high knees and butt kicks.

Key points: Start slowly, then gradually pick up the pace.



2 Forward lunge with trunk rotation

Arms straight out in front of you, take a big step forward and lower into a lunge, then turn your trunk and arms towards the front leg. Come back and switch legs.

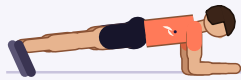
Key points: Front knee above the ankle, slow rotation.



3 Glute bridge

On your back, knees bent, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line, then lower.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top, do not arch your lower back. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



4 Plank

On your forearms and toes, body in a straight line from head to heels.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes and abs, breathe normally.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



5 Single-leg balance

On one foot, knee slightly bent, the other foot off the floor behind you, arms relaxed: hold the position without moving. To progress: close your eyes, then stand on a cushion.

Key points: The knee stays over the foot, the pelvis level.



6



Small jump, stable landing

Small jump on the spot, land softly on both feet and hold the position for 2 seconds.

Key points: Land on the balls of your feet, knees bent and in line with your toes: they never cave inwards. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

7

Progressive accelerations

Run 15 m, building up speed: 60 %, then 80 %, then 90 % of your top speed. Walk back.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.

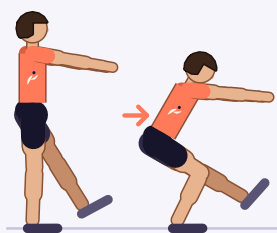
8

15-15 intervals

15 seconds of fast running, 15 seconds of walking or very slow jogging, continuously.

Key points: Same distance on every rep: pick a finish point.

Easier: 15 seconds fast, 30 seconds of recovery.



9

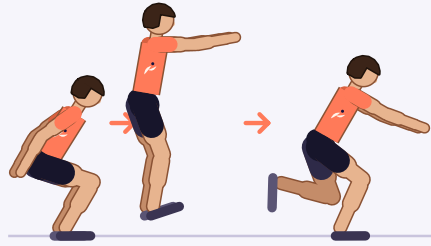


Single-leg squat

On one leg, the other leg straight out in front and your arms forward for balance: slowly lower into a quarter squat then stand back up.

Key points: The knee does not cave inwards.

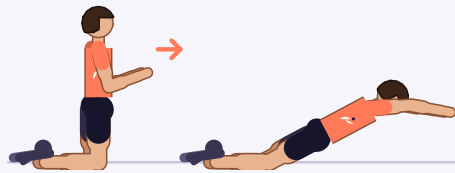
Easier: With a hand on a wall.



10 Single-leg landing

Small hop forwards, land on one leg with the other foot in the air, hold for 3 seconds. Once you have it, also hop sideways, then diagonally.

Key points: Land softly, knee in line with your foot. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

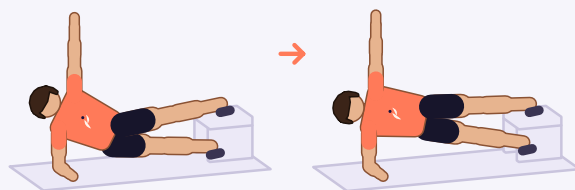


11 Nordic hamstring curl

Kneeling on a cushion, feet anchored under the sofa or held by another person, lean forward as slowly as possible, body straight. Catch yourself with your hands, then push back up with your hands.

Key points: Hips extended: the body stays straight from the knees to the head.

Easier: Shorter descent.



12 Copenhagen plank

On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder), top leg resting on the sofa or a chair (at the knee, or at the foot to make it harder). Lift your hips, reach your top arm up to the ceiling and hold the position.

Key points: Body in line: the inside of the top thigh does the work.

13 Handball shuttles

Back and forth between two lines 10 m apart: forwards, side shuffling and backwards.

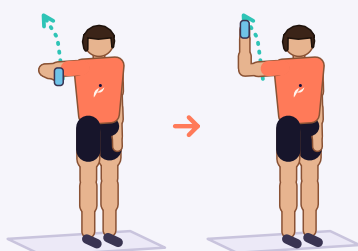
Key points: Stay low in the changes of direction.

14 Easy run

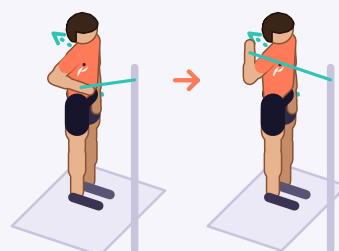
Continuous running at a pace where you can hold a conversation.

Key points: If you cannot talk, slow down or alternate running and walking.

At home



With a band

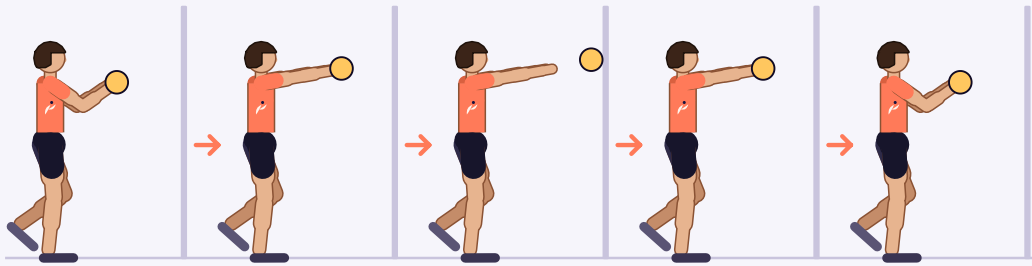


15 External rotation, arm raised

Standing tall, arm out to the side at shoulder height, elbow at 90°, a water bottle in your hand, forearm pointing forward: rotate your forearm upwards (the hand rises towards the ceiling, the elbow does not move), then lower slowly.

With a band: Band anchored in front of you: upper arm horizontal, elbow at 90°, rotate your forearm upwards.

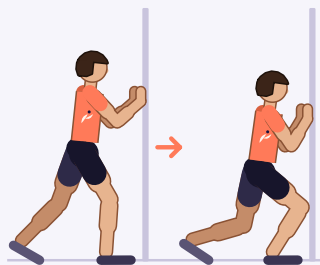
Key points: Slow and controlled, pain-free.



16 Balance with a ball

On one leg, throw a ball against a wall and catch it. Harder: standing on a folded cushion.

Key points: The standing knee stays in line.



17 Ankle mobility at the wall

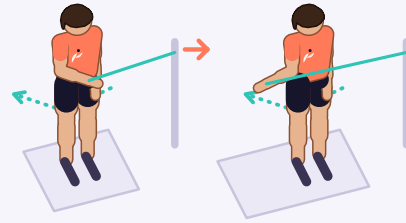
Facing a wall, hands on it, front foot 10 cm from the wall and the other foot behind: drive your front knee forward to touch the wall without lifting your heel.

Key points: Heel glued to the floor. Move your foot back if it is easy.

At home



With a band



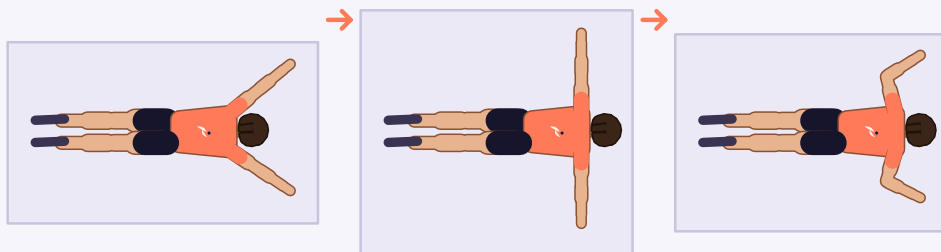
18 Shoulder external rotation

Lying on your side, top elbow tucked against your waist and bent at 90°, a water bottle in your hand, forearm resting in front of your belly: lift your forearm towards the ceiling by pivoting around the elbow (the hand moves away from your belly), then lower slowly.

With a band: Standing, band anchored to the side: elbow tucked in, move your forearm outwards.

Key points: The elbow does not move, 2 seconds on the way back.

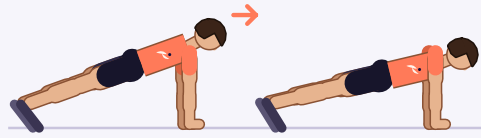
Easier: Without a band.



19 Y-T-W

Lying face down, forehead on a towel. Lift your arms off the floor to draw three letters with your body: Y (arms straight, diagonally above your head), T (arms out to the sides), then W (elbows bent, pulled in close to your ribs). Hold each letter for 2 seconds, squeezing your shoulder blades.

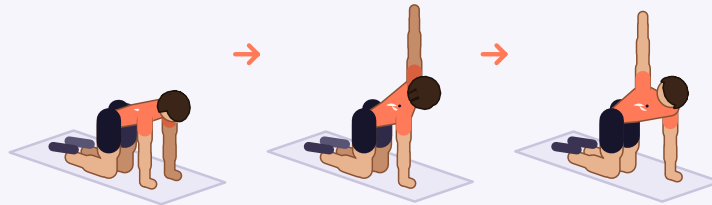
Key points: Thumbs towards the ceiling, no arching.



20 Scapular push-ups

In a straight-arm plank, squeeze then spread your shoulder blades without bending your elbows.

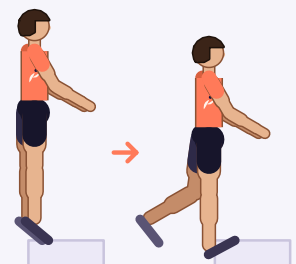
Key points: Small movement: only the shoulder blades move.



21 Upper back rotation

On all fours, hands under your shoulders. Rotate your upper back as you reach one arm towards the ceiling, following your hand with your eyes, then bring it back down and do the same with the other arm.

Key points: The pelvis does not move.



22 Calves: slow lowering

On the edge of a stair step, rise onto the balls of both feet, then lower over 3 seconds on one foot.

Key points: The heel goes below the level of the step.



23 90/90 hip mobility

Seated on the floor, hands on the floor behind you, feet flat and wider than your hips, knees up. Let both knees drop to the same side into the 90/90 position: front leg bent at 90° in front of you, back leg bent at 90° out to the side. Bring the knees back up through the middle and over to the other side, like windscreen wipers.

Key points: Upright trunk, slow movement. Only go as far as your hips allow, pain-free.

24 Repeated sprints

6 sprints of 20 m. You go again every 20 seconds: the time left is for walking back.

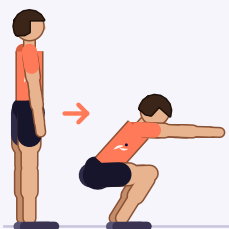
Key points: Every sprint flat out.

25 30-30 intervals

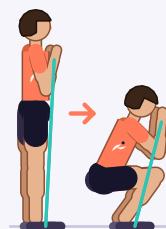
30 seconds fast (you can only say a few words), 30 seconds of jogging.

Key points: Steady pace from one rep to the next.

At home



With a band



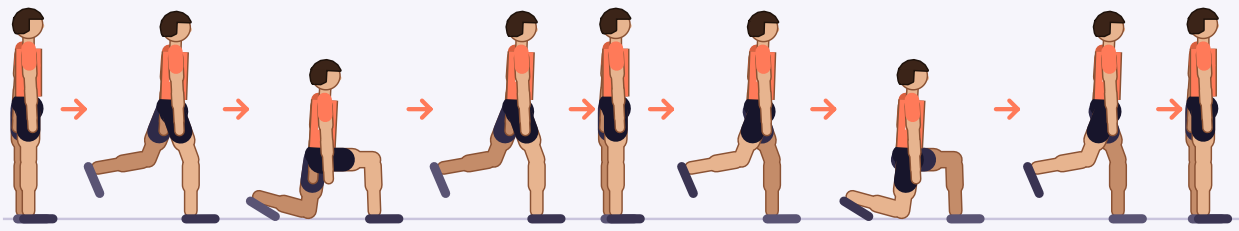
26 Squat

Feet shoulder-width apart, arms straight out in front, lower as if sitting down, thighs at least parallel to the floor, then stand up. When it gets easy: a weighted backpack held tight against your chest.

With a band: Band under your feet, held at your shoulders: it resists as you stand up.

Key points: Straight back, heels on the floor, knees in line with your feet.

Easier: Sit down on a chair and stand up.



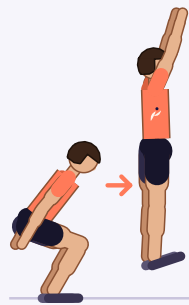
27 Reverse lunge

Step one leg back and lower until the back knee almost touches the floor. Come back by pushing through the front leg, then switch legs (the front foot stays planted). When it gets easy: a weighted backpack.

With a band: Band under your front foot, held at your shoulders.

Key points: Upright trunk, front knee above the ankle.

Easier: With support (wall, chair).

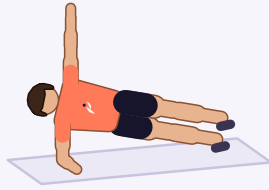


28 Squat jump

Lower into a half squat, pause for one second, then jump as high as you can. Stable landing.

Key points: Push hard into the floor, arms helping. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

Easier: Without the pause.



29



Side plank

On your side, on your forearm (elbow under the shoulder) and the edge of your foot, body in line, hips high, top arm reaching up to the ceiling.

Key points: The hips do not drop.

Easier: Knees on the floor.